

Outsider's Agony

A Cinderella of the cyber age plays out her inner life in Bangalore



NETI, NETI: NOT THIS, NOT THIS
by ANJUM HASAN
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| By Geeta Doctor |

Sophie Das is a Cinderella of the cyber age. She could just as well be called a Bengali Bridget Jones scrabbling to find a painted toenail in the busy, bustling, bad Big City of Bengaluru as depicted by Anjum Hasan, except that unlike our materially obsessed Bridget, Sophie has a rich inner life. Well, sort of, if you allow for the fact that she measures

her experiences as a young woman making her way into the world, with those of Emma Bovary. R.K. Narayan's *Swami and Friends* and fitting somewhat oddly with this group, Swami Vivekananda flaunting his orange turban for good effect.

It must be for the same interior compulsions i.e. the comfort of the past that Hasan persists in calling Sophie's city Bangalore. Though, just as clearly, though she does not make this distinction, this is the schizoid city that now calls itself Bengaluru with its malls, cyber cafes, chaotic traffic and the even more frantic lifestyles of its denizens who are trying different ways of escaping from the kitchen sink of their lives. Sophie is an orphan in many different ways. She has cut herself loose from her childhood home in Shillong and though an interlude in her parental home forms a part of her growing up and away from them, she realises that for internal extraterrestrials there's no going home anymore.

Alienation is their birth-right and

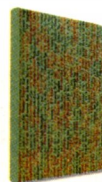
though this could be seen as a source of comic intensity in the hands of a more *bindaas* observer, one who does not have lines such as "Maya exhaled a sarcastic plume of smoke into her face" which begs the questions how can plumes be sarcastic, or savage in the manner of a Paul Theroux who encapsulates everything that Hasan has to say about her city in a short story, here it seems more like dialogue out of a reality show.

It's already been well-established that people who work in BPOs and call centres have lives of synapse-snapping tedium. Bengaluru is the ultimate cliché of a cyber connected metropolis, so to read about just such a series of blow-outs involving cyber nerds is hardly going to be edifying. There's a murder of a cyber chick, the reminder of a tragic real-life episode in which a young boy falls to his death in a mall, while on a Sunday outing with his young parents and vignettes of the gratuitous street violence that all of us witness and from which we turn away. Hasan records this with the zeal of a reformer, maybe it's the Vivekananda effect.

Meanwhile, to go back to Sophie, the wicked stepmother in her life is her Kannadiga landlord who objects amongst other things to her hanging out her wet underwear on the clothesline outside her rented flat as being injurious to the happiness of the moral majority in the building. Mr Bhatt himself is not above board and at some point has to face his nemesis in the form of loan sharks. It's low dishonest decade in which the only hope seems a chance to migrate to Australia. Given the fate that awaits young Asian immigrants there, one can only take Maya's remedy and exhale a carcinogenic plume of sarcastic smoke. ■



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